



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 24

MINNESOTA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Minnesota's family courts and child-welfare system.

40

MINNESOTA FAMILIES ON RECORD ·
61 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 13 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 26, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
20 OF 87

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

MINNESOTA AT A GLANCE.

Across 40 Minnesota families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 61 40 of 40 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$15,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 13 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 52.5% 35.0% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 40	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.5	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 40 of 40	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 20

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Minnesota families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF MINNESOTA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	25	\$15,000	\$54,032	\$1,350,800
Lost Wages	20	\$16,000	\$90,450	\$1,809,000
Other Court Fees	20	\$1,400	\$23,258	\$465,154
Therapy / Evaluations	19	\$500	\$7,789	\$148,000
Reunification Services	18	\$50	\$14,592	\$262,650
GAL Fees	19	\$200	\$7,279	\$138,309
Asset Loss ¹	24	\$20,000	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$53,150	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$20,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		13	1.1 yrs
Mean months lost		44	3.7 yrs
Total across all families		1,180	98.3 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · MINNESOTA

Most families documenting in Minnesota are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Not provided		18	45%
Active case: stuck or delayed		13	32%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		5	12%
Case closed: within last 2 years		3	8%
Not in court but still affected		1	2%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		15	38%
Family Court Only		13	32%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		8	20%
Unknown		4	10%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		9	22%
Over 10 years		8	20%
3 – 5 years		6	15%
5 – 10 years		6	15%
6 months – 1 year		4	10%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		11	28%
Visitation Only		9	22%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)		6	15%
50/50 Joint		6	15%
Full Custody		4	10%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Scott		2	5%
Stearns		2	5%
Usa		1	2%
Lac Que Parle		1	2%
Wadena		1	2%
Becker		1	2%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		11	28%
Other: (Short answer)		10	25%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		6	15%
High Conflict Divorce		4	10%
Environmental/Poverty-Related (Lack of housing, utilities, etc.)		3	8%

05 PARENT VOICES — MINNESOTA

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



Covered up abuse and silenced my kids and myself. Has not protected my son he lives with the step sister that molested him full time now!

— MELISSA

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Lost my oldest son last 3 years of his life now that he is 19 he was taken away from me when he was 16 3 most important precious years of his life without due process no court hearings no nothing all because of carlton county here in cloquet minnesota one cps worker that made it [...]

— MINNESOTA PARENT · TISHINA

MORE VOICES FROM MINNESOTA

It all started when the county did abatement on my property an discriminate an used slang words against my kids an me for no reason at all an for things that where not even true in the front page of the newspaper then are house burnt down they came an took are kids for no reason [...]

— NICOLE

It has destroyed my children trust in there's someone to help. Caused unimaginable stress that affects day today normal things..

— ANGELA

It's broken me and I can only imagine the pain my children are in

— CAITLIN

Destroyed my family, killed one of my children, has separated all four of my children in two different housing placements

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



They attempted to silence and assassinate me, my children, my faith and used my belief in God to persecute me and eventually traffick my daughter Lillian.

— KATHRYN

My kids were taken because my oldest wanted to make false claims against me because he wanted to live with his dad. And he got caught with porn on his phone and having not so nice messages with other children and my son got my other so to say things that where not true because he [...]

— AMANDA

Placed my children into a transvestite sex ring . Of physical abuse ignored by a friend group very powerful in my town

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Ripped child from home and 2 siblings, extended family and child has no rights. Loss of finance's, freedom and business income, added stree and trauma to all.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They broke my family apart and never had no intentions of reniting us back together. I had 2 sets of twins and they stole my children.

— MOLLIE

This has traumatized and stolen our life from us. So many missed opportunities to be a normal person like everyone else, all because of a system that cycles families through a system that doesn't even work and leaves you financially broken and too stressed out to think straight.

— BUFFY

Stripped us from valuable time, stole crucial memories values and morals , killed my family members

— AMBER

Ripped us apart as a family and perpetuated abuse that was already failed to be addressed. I've said the damage is already done and it's true; but will not be in vain.

— STEPHANIE

I have 7 more children in SD since my case in mn which proves my case is the strongest and easiest case to win if I had a lawyer. Same county that stole my son had prior paid me as unlicensed daycare provider for my sister's kids. I have enough to file federal lawsuit and 3 [...]

— ROBIN

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Severely damaged my three children and their mental health, damaged my children's relationship and bond with me, and my family, financially destroyed me, causing significant debt.

— DONNA

Destroyed lives of people & property financial exploitation REVICTINIZATION Not to the BEST INTEREST THEY LIE

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My children were removed and court decisions were made before I was ever properly served or given notice, and I have been trying to participate in a process that moved forward without me. I initially intended to represent myself but was forced to request a court-appointed [...]

— ALICIA

Harassed, tormented and Traumatized and it's still continuing for over 5 years after I beat them.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Minnesota court system has failed way me and keep me from my children. After they where moved out of state for 2 years

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It is literally destroyed me. It is me and my kids super sad some moaning talk to me now because they think I wasn't there when I was the guy I tried make it seem like I didn't love my kids or something, but all I wanted was my kids they've turned me into a person that. Didn't [...]

— BRADLEY

I lost my job because of them I feel lost without them family is very upset

— BRITTANY

Disparaged and put in danger

— ALICIA

Taken valuable time and moments that we will never get back and the y drove a wedge between us. They do everything they could do divide and separate us when they were supposed to be reunifying our family

— TESSA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

Made my life complete hell. I'm amazed I'm still alive

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Made us hate each other more than we did before the divorce

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Caused major physical harm to my daughter, and made sure we couldn't live on our own for years. Sucked us financially dry...

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The family court system has profited from not only ripping my family apart; the one I gave up my career to build, but protecting the one who threw everything I build in the garbage, and continued to profit over allowing him to perpetuate neurological battery that has developed [...]

— SARA J

I can't change the cards I was dealt. I can only change the way I play the game. God always provides my team. A pawn can take out the King. The system tried to break us while God built us..

— JOCELYN

I made sure to have professionals backing up my claims thinking it would be a quick case. Because he has money he has been able to draw it out which is not in the best interest of the child. Courts don't care. It's just about the money.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

30 Minnesota parents submitted ranked quotes. 30 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/mn.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Minnesota report comes from Minnesota respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Minnesota — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 40 Minnesota families reporting here are not the universe of Minnesota families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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